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Eddie Alley

Eddie Alley was born in Minneapolis, Minnesota on December 19, 1910. His family moved to San Francisco while Eddie was a young man and the name Alley is now synonymous with music in the Bay Area. Throughout his life, Eddie played a role in the jazz and popular music scene as a drummer, band leader and musical contractor. He counts numerous jazz legends as friends and former bandmates.

Eddie was interviewed in San Francisco, California on August 8, 2002 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive. His daughter was present at the interview and participated briefly.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in San Francisco and we are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive and I know I'm going to enjoy talking to veteran drummer Eddie Alley. It's very nice to have you here.

EA: Thank you very much.

MR: And I just learned that you are 91 years young.

EA: I'll be 92 in December.

MR: Congratulations.

EA: Thank you.

MR: You know when I came into town and I started talking to different people, guys at the musician's union, and the name Alley came up right away, right away.

EA: It's a compliment.

MR: So it's nice to have you here.

EA: Very complimentary.

MR: When you grew up in San Francisco, I would guess it was different than it is now.

EA: All together different. I can tell you some reasons why. One reason, when I first grew up in Francisco there were two unions, there wasn't one union, and when I got out — the reason I became a musician, when I got out of school, why it was hard to get a job at different places, in those days, because I couldn't get a job on the streetcars, buses or stores, it was kind of a racial problem.

MR: Was it segregated then?

EA: Yeah.

MR: They wouldn't hire you?

EA: Not on streetcars, buses, none, so I red capped and then I shined shoes. The reason I became a musician is because in grammar school they had a contest, when they started band in grammar school. And I had more rhythm in the drums, so they said whoever wins the contest will get free lessons. So I won the contest as a drummer and they gave me

some free lessons. And then I worked in a place called Topsy's Roost, I used to play my drums to the phonograph records, this was about '29 or '30, 1930; I used to play my drums with phonograph records until the band came. The people would dance. I just played my drums and put the records on and people would dance until the band came at 9:00. So the union said, "Eddie, you have to join the union to do this, you're going to be a union musician." So I went to the Golden Gate School of Music and studied music so I could pass the test.

MR: What was the test like for the union?

EA: It was drumming.

MR: Did they make you play like —

EA: You had to read, had to read. Reading. That's what that meant, reading.

MR: Right.

EA: So I took the test and passed, and I came back and played to the phonograph records.

MR: And what kind of money would you make back then in 1929?

EA: I wouldn't get any money for playing music, I'd just get three dollars a night just for being a busboy, I just did that on the side.

MR: Oh I see. You were a busboy.

EA: In the twenties, about 1930, yeah, something like that, yeah '29. So I joined the union in 1930. I was just a busboy. But I always liked music.

MR: Did your parents have a thought about what you might do for a living?

EA: None. Not at all. But in fact, when we were little small kids my parents gave my sister piano lessons, and my brother became a big time musician, bigger than me, and I became a musician and my sister never became a musician, and they gave her the piano lessons.

MR: What did kids do, let's say when you were ten or twelve, do you remember what you would have done for fun?

EA: Well in my days, I came up in times that we used to play One Foot off the Gutter and simple games. I played basketball, and I played on the baseball team, we won the city championship for the Park League. And marbles. They don't shoot marbles anymore I don't think. They don't know what marbles are.

MR: Yeah. Were there many cars around in your neighborhood?

EA: Well I was raised in the Potrero district when I was a little kid. And in those days my family was the only black family in the Potrero district, and we didn't know the difference. I mean we got along perfectly out there. Perfect. Wonderful. In fact the lady upstairs visited us, Mrs. Salmon, and my mother had work to take care of her. She was a white lady, a Scotch lady I think, and it was beautiful. I knew nothing about segregation or nothing like that.

MR: That's interesting.

EA: And when I went to grammar school why I'm the one that usually stood on the platform and say, "I pledge allegiance to the flag" to all the kids, when I was in grammar school. So I never came in contact with any segregation until I got out of high school, looking for a job. That's when the problem came.

MR: I see. And did you have to go into the Army?

EA: No I didn't because at the time I had a couple of kids, I'm going to say essential and a non-essential industry. And I worked at the Metropolitan in those days and I was a flunky, what was I doing? Well the first job I had at the Metropolitan, I'll tell you a story if you don't mind, a little short story.

MR: That's why we're here.

EA: When I first went to the Metropolitan there was a job open on the elevator. And they said you're going to have a job if the uniform fits you. The uniform would have fit him. It was like a sack. So I pulled it and made it fit me. And so they said well you're never going to get off the elevator because you're colored. I said well I needed a job. And so I took a job for about three years, whatever — my father and mother always told me whatever I do, do the best, whatever it is. Whether it's cleaning the floor, whatever it is, just be the best. So I was never late, I was never out, and people liked me. I was polite and everything. And so about three years later I went to the big boss, the head of the eleven stations of the Metropolitan Life Insurance Company, and he told me to — I went to him and I said, his name was Mr. North, Henry North. I said, "I would like to get off the elevator, I think I'm capable of doing clerical work" because I went to school with a lot of the kids there, about ten or twelve other kids that worked at the Metropolitan Life Insurance Company. And I said, "I'd like to get off the elevator and get a clerical job." I know it wasn't the rules, whatever. So he thought about it and he said, he kind of liked me and he said, "I'm going to send you to the personnel manager and you tell him the story." I went to the personnel manager and the personnel manager patted me on the back, "Oh Eddie, you're a nice guy boy, the time isn't right right now though, but you're nice, and when the time comes why we'll think about you" you know. So he sent me back to Mr. North the head guy. And I told him what he said. Mr. North called up the personnel manager up again and he said, "I'm sending Eddie Alley back to you this time and don't give him the runaround this time." So they took me off the elevator and I got a clerical job. And so to make a long story short, I became a — I got in the payroll division where they paid all their agents, because I was pretty good at math. I had to take a test too. After about twelve years I didn't think I could pass it but I passed it, because I wasn't any dummy. And I passed the test and then I became in the payroll division for the clerks. And then later on — I had a few little problems and things, and then later on I became a supervisor of another department and I ended up my career at the Metropolitan.

MR: Yeah. Were you, while you were doing this job, you were starting to play drums with different people?

EA: Well what put me over at the Metropolitan was I had a little band. And I played with their picnics and things. So that helped me to win the people over and win everybody over, see? Music was the thing that helped me, in all those situations.

MR: Right. With your band, what kind of songs would you have played? Like Ellington things?

EA: I played Ellington ballads, I played the number ten songs. It wasn't way out or nothing like that. The people could dance together.

MR: Yeah. Oh people could dance together.

EA: Yeah people could dance together with the music I played.

MR: Right.

EA: I played ballads and swing tunes and everything you know. I didn't play nothing way out. Because I had to play for a lot of, you know, older people too sometimes.

MR: Sure.

EA: I'll never forget one time a woman called me up down around Menlo Park or someplace. She called me up on the telephone and I think I was recommended by somebody, and when I appeared down there and knocked on the door she said to me, "You Eddie Alley?" I said yes. She didn't know I was black kid you know. I thought she was going to die. I saw all these guys with gray hair and tuxedos and things on, and see that was my thing. I could play beautiful ballads and things, you know, "Fascination" and all those kinds of stuff. I had that kind of a band. I didn't play boom-bam-boom-bam-boom or — I played where they could dance together. I sized the people up in about four or five tunes. "Where'd you get this band, this is the best band you ever had." And before I left, "Mr. Alley you've got this date, Mr. Alley you've got this date."

MR: That's cool. Well that's a big part of being a successful musician is reading the crowd, right?

EA: Yes. That was the first black bands that ever played at any of the hotels. the Fairmont, the Mount Hopkins, all the big hotels, I was one of the first black bands that ever played any of these hotels.

MR: Yeah. What kind of money would your band have played for?

EA: Well whatever the union was in those days, scale, union scale. I forgot what it was. I forgot what the scale was in those days. It was all right. I should have brought my sales book but I didn't.

MR: Well we can find that out, we could do some research and find that out. What about the social clubs that were going on at that time?

EA: Well another thing that happened during the war years, a lot of black people migrated from the south here. And a lot of these black people began forming clubs. And I was the number one band for their clubs because I got them dancing together in the right way and things like that. And so I was booked a year in advance all the time. And then other people, heard about — and then the politicians heard about me and I played for the politicians. And they all liked me because I went to school here and I knew everybody and so it was easier for me to cross over.

MR: Were you the, like the leader of the band?

EA: I was the leader. Yeah. Eddie Alley and his Gentlemen of Rhythm.

MR: Ah. Eddie Alley and his Gentlemen of Rhythm.

EA: Don't know if I have a card on me or not, that's what it was. Eddie Alley and his Gentlemen of Rhythm.

MR: Okay. Did you ever have discipline problems with any of your musicians?

EA: No because I never drank or smoked.

MR: I see.

EA: Believe it or not. In my day I didn't even smoke. I'm one of the rare guys that never did that.

MR: Oh. Yeah. Because it was just kind of accepted.

EA: And I never allowed anybody to get drunk. See I knew what I had to do. I had to have discipline. Because I played for society people. I played for the big politicians. And I couldn't have some guy coming in drunk or unruly or anything like that. I was class. I had to have class. We had uniforms and everything. I have one picture, they were, anyway, and so I just had a standard. So as I said I played for all the big — Dianne Feinstein and Quentin Kopp, I don't know if you've heard of Senator Quentin, he was senator, and Phil Burton, he's the senator now, and his brother Burton, and all the politicians. I played for all of them. That's what got me started. And I played, and we were disciplined and we were dressed nice, no drinking. We were disciplined and I played the right kind of music. And that helped me.

MR: Did you have singers in the band?

EA: I had a girl singer.

MR: Yup.

EA: And I used to sing in my early days. I can't even talk now. You wouldn't believe it now. But I sang a little bit myself. But I had to, I hired a girl singer. And I had a nice — we played, the people danced together.

MR: Yeah. You mean they actually touched each other.

EA: Yeah. That kind of thing.

MR: Wow. Interesting. The North Beach area, was there some kind of problem later on with white bands trying to take the work in that district?

EA: Well I'll tell you in the real early years, there's a book here of mine with pictures in it I guess, in 1937 I think. Well in other words, in the early years they had two unions. And at one time a black musician couldn't play east of Van Ness Avenue. You understand? Van Ness Avenue. But I played — it wasn't my band — I was playing with another band and he had a job that played in North Beach. This was in, oh the real early thirties. It wasn't my band, but I played. And we played over in North Beach and well the union said we couldn't play there because we were past the boundary. But there was a guy named Lou Parenti, he owned a joint on Pacific Avenue. He was like a little Capone or somebody I guess, a little Italian — a little Caesar. He said, "They're gonna play here." And we played there. And I remember the first movie star I ever met was Lilyan Tashman and Edmund Lowe. I don't know if you go that far back in the movies.

MR: Lilyan?

EA: Tashman and Edmund Lowe. This was the early thirties. And so we played in North Beach then, one of the first bands.

MR: This Lou fella, he had the muscle to say —

EA: He said "they're going to play here." Now, like that was it.

MR: Wow. So and this was obviously the white local that was telling you that you couldn't do that.

EA: Yes the white local. Later on they amalgamated naturally you know, I forgot. Earl Watkins told you the history about that I guess.

MR: Earl told me about that.

EA: I forgot what year and all that, but things changed. And he's on the board of directors even. Things changed altogether. But I never was bitter about anything. In fact I never was bitter in my life. I've got as many white friends as I have black friends. And that's what helped me. I had a mixed band too.

MR: Oh you had a mixed band.

EA: Oh yeah. Well I grew up that way. I didn't grow up this and that. See I grew up with white kids all my life and so I was used to it. It didn't bother me. I didn't have any complex or anything.

MR: Right. Who were the drummers that you liked to listen to?

EA: Well my favorite drummers I guess, well naturally one of the old ones was Gene Krupa naturally. Buddy Rich was a good friend of mine. And oh gee, what's the guy, he played with Dizzy Gillespie, what's his name? Oh Jesus there were several of them.

MR: In the big band or in the small group?

EA: In the big band era, yeah. And Duke Ellington's first drummer.

MR: Sam Woodyard?

EA: Sam Woodyard was one of my favorites. Kept real good time. In fact Clark Terry told me — did you ever hear of Clark Terry? He is a great trumpet player.

MR: Oh yeah.

EA: He's one of my buddies.

MR: He's been to our school, he's a nice man.

EA: Well he's one of my buddies.

MR: Is that right?

EA: He told me Sam Woodyard, because I liked Sam Woodyard, and oh Jo Jones. Papa Jo Jones. He's one of my favorites.

MR: Would any of these fellas, when they came into town, you would have them over to your house?

EA: Oh all of them came over my house. Papa Jo Jones did, Ben Webster did. Dizzy Gillespie did. I had Oscar Peterson over to my mother's house for dinner, you know, Oscar Peterson. James Moody, I don't know if you ever heard of him. Sweets Edison came over my house. Well the reason they came over to my house was because it was a home atmosphere, had kids, they could be themselves. They could get on the floor, sit down and relax, they didn't have to put on any airs and my wife was a good cook and they liked my kids. And so they felt at home. I gave them a home atmosphere. And they really loved it. They knew my brother before they knew me. But they liked me because of my home atmosphere I had in my home. See I had four kids. And I never traveled or nothing. I was always a home type of guy.

MR: So your kids were having these famous musicians in their house.

EA: Oh yes.

MR: And they probably didn't really know —

EA: These guys were the greatest that ever lived. Dizzy Gillespie and these guys, the greatest that ever lived. Oscar Peterson.

MR: Wow.

EA: Papa Jo Jones, Papa Jo Jones, and Ben Webster, Clark Terry. Clark Terry is one of my best friends. And he's a giant.

MR: What was Ben Webster like as a person?

EA: Let me tell you something. They tell me Ben Webster was one of the roughest cats in the world outside. I remember they told me a story one time that one time he was always getting in fights and different things. They were by my house and he was one of the nicest guys I ever met in my life. He liked the home life. He'd take his shoes off, would play music, he was a wonderful man. But they tell me on the outside, I didn't see this part of him, he'd tear up a joint once in a while. But around me, I think that's why he liked

me, because I reminded him of when he was a kid, his home life. See I wasn't that great a — it wasn't because I was such a great musician or nothing like that. I was a musician, but I had a good home life. They liked the atmosphere I brought him in.

MR: Well you seem to have a good business sense for a musician, because you ended up doing like some contracting.

EA: Oh I really did. Gene Kelly and Nelson Riddle and — oh I can tell you a lot of stories if you want to hear some of them.

MR: That's why we're here. Well I think, I did a little of that myself, and I think that can be a high pressure thing because you're hiring people and you really need them to do a great job.

EA: You have to.

MR: And you're responsible if they don't.

EA: I did that Lipizzaner Horse Show for about five years. You ever hear of that Lipizzaner Horse Show?

MR: Oh yeah.

EA: I was the contractor of that for about five years. I didn't play, I wasn't that good, you know I hired the band, I was the contractor.

MR: Right.

EA: Did that for about five years. Gene Kelly had his show here called "Clown Around." Lisa said somebody else was in it. Anyway the thing called "Clown Around" they played in Oakland Auditorium and played over here in the Cow Palace. And the couldn't afford it because the paraphernalia was so extravagant and it was too costly to move. So they ended it right here. But Gene Kelly, it was his show, he wasn't in it. He didn't perform in it, but it was his show. He's the one that produced it and everything. And I met him you know, he's a nice guy, we shook hands, and I met Gene Kelly and I was a contractor for Gladys Knight and the Pips. Well I'll tell you a story about Bob Cosby that's funny.

LA: Bill Cosby

EA: Years ago there was —

MR: Bob Crosby or Bill Cosby?

EA: Bill Cosby.

MR: Okay because there was a Bob Crosby.

EA: Bill Cosby. But years ago Save a Band came to the State instead of going to the auditorium, I believe the classification was 18 pieces, and Bill Cosby came and he had Sarah Vaughan with him with a quartet, saying Bill Cosby was on the show and then Sarah Vaughan came with her quartet. So the local musicians, they had to bring in 16 more musicians, whatever it was, to make up that classification. And that's the way it was. And so the union went a little too far sometimes. But anyway he was in the

auditorium one time and he understood all that, but usually when we had these extra musicians we just come and pick up our check and leave. He said, "You guys are going to play?" So I always had a mixed band. So he got up on the stage and he had fun with us. He said, "Not on the white guy, the black guy, come up and play solo; no not the black guy the white guy." He made fun. The people just roared, he made a joke out of the whole thing. Bill Cosby. But he finally showed up, about a half an hour just ahead of our band, laughing and everything. So we had a little prank, but we were supposed to play anyway, you know, they could hear you do that. But the music, you get paid anyway, but he said, "You guys are going to play something." So he thought he'd have some fun with us.

MR: Well he loves jazz too, doesn't he?

EA: Yeah. But I didn't know he was a good friend of my brother's at the time though, he wouldn't remember me I don't think. I was the band leader. That was my band. It was really funny. He had a lot of fun with us.

MR: Well let me see, you had this list of people. Let me see that list for a moment. You know what Earl Watkins told me?

EA: What?

MR: He said that the first drumset he ever played on—

EA: Was mine.

MR: Was yours.

EA: Yeah, yeah, yes it was. See what happened, I was going to be a musician. I played with Billie Holiday too you know, I played for her.

MR: Yeah? Where was that?

EA: It was the a place, The Savoy down where Macy's is now. Where is the Macy's on Market? Where is Macy's Lisa? On O'Farrell near Powell? It's a big store down there.

LA: Everybody knows, it's the Macy's in San Francisco.

EA: It's downtown Macy's, near Powell or something. It's a big store. But there used to be a nightclub in there.

LA: The Club Savoy.

EA: And I was playing with a fella by the name of Saunders King's Band, Saunders King. And I was the drummer. Did you ever hear of Mingus?

MR: Sure.

EA: Mingus was in the band. And Billie Holiday, I was excited playing for Billie Holiday and I was scared stiff because she scared me to death. Because she's a big shot, you know, I'm a little guy you know. And Saunders King was the leader. I wasn't the leader. She liked me, because she liked that I played soft behind her, I was a good brush man. And she called me —

MR: What did she call you now?

EA: Sweet little "mf."

MR: But she said it with affection, right?

EA: Yeah. But I was scared of her.

MR: I can understand that. I can hear that.

EA: Because I was always shy you know what I'm talking about? And she could tell. Because these other guys would try to pull it off to show how hip they were. You could tell I wasn't that type. I was in awe of her.

MR: She didn't need someone to show—

EA: She liked me because I was for real.

MR: Okay.

EA: And she liked somebody down to earth. These guys might try to put her on, and so, here's another story though. There's two guys that used to come in the place every night, two guys, and sit in the corner. And they said they were songwriters. I said don't pay any attention to them, I said that's nice. So about five years later, when Tony Bennett had that song "I Left My Heart in San Francisco," I found out these are the guys that wrote the song. If I had known that I would have shaked hands with them.

MR: See if you could get on the record.

EA: But I didn't pay any attention to these two guys.

MR: Wow.

EA: But these are the guys that wrote "I Left My Heart in San Francisco," and he just added that to his — you heard the story about that — he just added that song onto whatever his record date was.

MR: Yeah.

EA: It wasn't in his record date at first, he just threw that in because he needed another song. And it became the number one song. And these are the two guys that wrote it. I used to see them all the time, came in there. If I'd have known it—little things like that.

MR: I see Vince Guaraldi's name on here.

EA: Well Vince Guaraldi, he played for "Peanuts." Did you ever hear that —

MR: Sure.

EA: Well he played the piano player. Well I hired Vince Guaraldi, when he first started out he didn't have anything, and he thanked me later, he said, "Eddie, you helped me out when I really needed help." He was a heck of a piano player. So he played with me. He played with my little outfit. I had some good musicians that played with me. That's the thing right there.

MR: How long did you have this band for?

EA: My band?

MR: Yeah.

EA: Well I played for about fifty years.

MR: Yeah. So you started in 19 — let's see, you were saying 30? Around 1930?

EA: Oh I guess so. Well the forties. The war. Right at the end of the war I started. And when the war ended why I formed my band then. When was that?

MR: '45, '46.

EA: Something like that. That's when I really got started. And I played up 'till a year ago.

MR: That's great. Do you have any recollection of the Depression years? See you would have been —

EA: Oh yeah, '29, sure I was in school. I can describe that school for you. But it didn't have any effect, we were poor all our lives. So the Depression didn't bother me. People jumping out the windows. It didn't bother me, we were poor anyway.

MR: What did your father do for a living?

EA: Well my father, when I was a little kid I understand he was a barber in Minneapolis. I was born in Minneapolis. But then he came out here. When he came out here he did menial work like in the barber shop shining shoes and cleaning up and things like that, just menial work. So things like that didn't bother us at all. We were struggling all our lives. That was for rich people that had money and lost it.

MR: Yeah, well okay, that makes sense, that makes sense.

EA: We struggled all our lives.

MR: What was — can you recall what it was like to get your first drumset? Was it a big event?

EA: Oh yeah. I got my first set from a guy names Jess Priserssen, I think he was from Sweden. Anyway he had a drum shop downtown here and he took a liking to me. That's my luck. People just took a liking to me and helped me a lot. I got a lot of help from other people and that's why I was never prejudiced because a lot of white guys helped me too. You know I was never raised, I hate this guy and that guy and that guy because I got help from so many, people of all races, you know, really helped me. I take people for who they are. They like me and I like them.

MR: Yeah well it seems to be a mutual —

EA: That's the way it was. I never did have any chip on my shoulder like some guys do — I hate this, that, them guys, nothing like that.

MR: How did you get, you know this might seem like a silly question but how did you get your drumset around when you had to get from one place — did you have a car?

EA: Well I had a car, yeah. I had a little trunk and a chest. Yes. And this guy — and the guys like they'd always give me a bargains on my drums because they knew I was scuffling. And this guy, I think he was from Sweden or someplace, and he always took a liking to me, he said, "Eddie, I'll give you this for a bargain." He always did give me a break.

People helped me a lot. I got to thank a lot of people for helping me on my way up. Like I didn't say I did it all myself, or I was great or nothing like that, I'm not that type. There for the grace of God, people helped me, were nice to me.

MR: Tell me about when the unions came together.

EA: Yes. Well that was very good because then we could really go to the same meetings and we had camaraderie together and things like that, and so that was a lot of help. That's the way it should be, because that's how I grew up. I grew up — see I'm not one of these guys that just came from the south that was segregated. I was around segregation but per se. I was always in the north and I didn't know anything about segregation per se.

MR: Okay. Because the schools you went to were not segregated.

EA: All integrated, yeah. I might have been the only one there.

MR: But no one said you couldn't. But were there Asian families too?

EA: Well I went to Polytechnic High School there was a couple of Asian families. There wasn't that many here, not like it is now, oh boy so many now. But there was a couple. And not too many black kids at Polytechnic. I was the only one that graduated in my class.

MR: I see.

EA: And when I graduated from high school we were pretty poor and my mother cried because she couldn't get me a new suit. And I said momma don't cry about it, because we were pretty poor. But I was always able to face life the way it is. And I was never bitter.

MR: And how many children?

EA: There was three of us. My sister died some years ago. There was three of us, my brother — my brother is a big shot — not me, I'm the little guy. He is the one that played with Count Basie and Lionel Hampton and Sarah Vaughan and all the big people. I just played locally. I'm the little guy.

MR: Yeah but you had your role.

EA: Oh I did little things. I did my little number. I says, the names I've met, these people I came in contact with. But I didn't travel like he did you know or things like that. And the people I did meet really liked me a lot like Ben Webster and Dizzy. They really took a liking to me for some reason and we got along great. In fact when I first went to New York Jo Jones, Papa Jo Jones the drummer with Basie, he took me all over New York. So I always got along great with these great musicians.

MR: In the big ballrooms—

EA: Um hum, I played in Sweet's Ballroom in Oakland, I played over there.

MR: Okay, the big bands would come through I would imagine. Who did you get to hear?

EA: Well my favorite band, my first favorite band of all time in the beginning was Jimmie Lunceford. Jimmie Lunceford knocked me out. That's what I tried to pattern my style after. "Sweet Swing."

MR: "Sweet Swing."

EA: Yeah. It was a popular song and he swung it, you know? It was just different. Jimmie Lunceford was my man. And then naturally we had to play a lot of Duke Ellington tunes because Harold Brown the trombone player in Duke Ellington, he was another personal friend of mine, I'd put his name down there. Did you ever hear of Harold Brown the trombone player?

MR: Lawrence Brown?

EA: Lawrence Brown. A personal friend of mine. His father used to be a preacher here.

MR: No kidding.

EA: Because I knew Lawrence Brown way back and he'd call me up. All these guys, these big shots just liked me. These were big boys.

MR: Well sometimes they didn't think of themselves as big shots.

EA: No they didn't. They liked what I was. And Lawrence Brown was one of my best friends.

MR: Wow. I'm trying to remember, I think Earl was telling me about the bands that came and would play some nights for the white audience and some nights for the black audience.

EA: Yes they did. Over at Sweet's, over there, yeah. It was that way yeah. Yeah they did have that. It Thad's Ballroom or Sweet's, I forgot, over in Oakland. Most of the dances were in Oakland, more so than San Francisco. We'd go over there, the first time I heard Lunceford and those bands. And I played at Sweet's myself but they played at Sweet's or at Thad's Ballroom. And then it was segregated at one time, then later on it changed.

MR: Yeah. Things got better as time went on.

EA: Oh yeah.

MR: What other kinds of jobs did you do over the years that were non-music jobs? Lots of things?

EA: Shined shoes — red capped down on Third and Townsend where the trains come in, washed windows at the Metropolitan, run an elevator. A lot of menial work.

MR: Yeah. But you said you did it well.

EA: I did it well. My father told me whatever you do — and that's why I got promotions. I'm the first person in the history of the Metropolitan — because whatever I did I did it well and they took a liking to me. And I wasn't bitter. I didn't go around with a chip on my shoulder, and I made friends. It means a heck of a lot, because you've got people on your side then you know. They said, "I'm glad Eddie got that job, I'm glad he got a break," because more were pulling for me. That's what — people don't understand that.

MR: Did you work in any one place long enough to get a retirement type of thing?

EA: Oh I retired from the Metropolitan, sure.

MR: That's good. I'm glad to hear that.

EA: I retired in '76. And in fact I have lunch with my vice president every once in a while now, he's the one that helped me out a lot too, George Preble, he was one of the vice presidents at Metropolitan. He was one of my best friends. In fact I talked to him yesterday.

MR: That's terrific.

EA: He was one of the vice presidents. But I have that kind of a relationship with people. You know that means a heck of a lot.

MR: I'm looking at something, an inaugural ball for Jimmy Carter. January 1977. The Eddie Alley Orchestra.

EA: Yeah. I also played for Kennedy, before he was president. I was in one truck — he was running for president, I had a big band, I had a ten piece band, we were on trucks in Oakland. And I always had an integrated band. That's another thing that helped me out a lot.

MR: Yeah I bet it did.

EA: See politicians liked that. I was always using my noodle you know.

MR: Yeah, sure. I like this — this is 1977 — it says Donor's Choice, five dollars, ten, up to twenty-five dollars. My how things have changed.

EA: You ever hear of Senator Burton?

MR: Yes.

EA: Well his brother, Phil Burton's the one that gave me my big start.

MR: Now who are these people?

EA: That's Pee Wee, he was one of my best saxophone — Claybrook.

MR: Pee Wee Claybrook.

EA: He was a heavy — he's from St. Louis originally. Right after the war I got him, he had one of the most beautiful tones you ever want to hear. That's what put me over. He had that beautiful tone. So when I played for — see before I sat and played a lot of these black bands were playing a lot of loud sound — blah blah blah blah. And I came around with this stuff that people danced together, smooth or something, with the right tone and everything, and things change you know, the people could dance together. And I was accepted by white society also. That's why we got to go down to the big hotels.

MR: Oh my. And here's Eddie Alley Day in San Francisco.

EA: Oh, Willie Brown gave me that, had a day for me, the mayor. I played for him when he graduated from law school. And then the supervisors gave me a proclamation. Because like I said before, I never traveled like these other guys or nothing like that, I'm just local.

MR: There's nothing wrong with that. It's terrific. What are some of the biggest changes you've seen in your life, not just in music.

EA: Well one thing is bringing down of prejudice, I mean people are getting along better now with each other. I'm not saying, there's still a little bit left I guess, naturally, but people don't look at that as much anymore. You've got people working all together, all races working together now. Look at — I remember I was a heck of a baseball player when I was a kid. I didn't have a chance to become a baseball player.

MR: That's right.

EA: Jackie Robinson hadn't come along yet.

MR: Forty — gosh when was that 1943 or something.

EA: Don Barksdale was about the second or third basketball player in pro basketball, a personal friend of mine.

MR: Who was that?

EA: Don Barksdale was his name. And that was a breakthrough. And now look at it.

MR: Yeah.

EA: So I've seen all these changes. But these guys don't realize that, I mean some of these guys. They ought to pool their money and help other people. All these rich guys making all this big money, they don't realize how fortunate they are. I mean if — we didn't have the breaks that they're getting now. Well they're getting a bigger cut because of their ability but I mean we couldn't do that.

MR: I see. You didn't have the opportunity.

EA: No. These guys gee, they earn everything now, they have more freedom and everything. It's a heck of a lot of changes.

MR: And this city has grown quite a bit.

EA: Oh sure. Entirely different. The first black mayor, I remember Willie Brown when he used to come around and holler — hey, hey, blah blah blah, before he was a big man. Now he's mayor of the city. And I played for a lot of these politicians and things. The world has changed quite a bit.

MR: What's happened to the cost of living over the years?

EA: Oh it's terrible. Terrible. Boom. The thing of it is the guys that are retired are having a tougher time though because the little pension I get is running out, because the cost of living is so much higher now. But I still make it — I've got good kids that help me a lot. My daughter and my three boys. I've got wonderful kids.

MR: Do they all live —

EA: Around here, yeah. My daughter is a bilingual school teacher. She was with the University of Madrid in Spain in one year, exchange student, I'm proud of her. All my kids I'm proud of.

MR: Well I bet the feeling is mutual too.

EA: Well I tried to set a good example for them.

MR: Did you have a role in helping Vernon get started in music?

EA: At the beginning, yes. Oh I'm the first one that introduced music to my house. I'm the first one that bought a phonograph to play records on. And I was the first one to get into music. I won this drum contest in grammar school at the Daniel Webster, and then he went to Commerce, but he had so much talent he passed me like I was standing still, because he went with all the big bands later on.

MR: You should have asked him for a cut.

EA: Well I wanted a different lifestyle anyway. I like my lifestyle better. I had a family with my kids, and I did what I wanted to do. I didn't want to travel with big bands or nothing like that. It's nice to say that but I'd rather have my home life with my family like I have. I wouldn't trade places.

MR: That's good. Who do you like to listen to nowadays? Do you have records you play or CDs you play?

EA: I have some records of my own, some tapes, a few of them, yeah. My favorite bands were Jimmie Lunceford as I said before, Duke Ellington, and I liked Artie Shaw and Benny Goodman, and I liked all those old bands. I don't like some of this new music. I guess I'm old fashioned. She and I might disagree, some of the stuff I don't like some of the — hip music I don't think of that stuff at all. I like something I can understand. I'm just old fashioned. To each his own.

MR: Sure. Each generation has their things they like. And are you in this book here? This is "Jazzography?"

EA: I'm in this book in 1937 I think. No. No, I'm not in this, my brother's in this.

MR: Okay. Did your band ever get recorded?

EA: No I never recorded.

MR: Oh that's too bad.

EA: No I never did. See I just played casuals. I was — as I said before — I was never a big shot or nothing like that.

MR: Yeah. But you know some night someone might have a tape recorder up there.

EA: Yeah people tell me that, wish I would record, I've got tapes at home though. If you were ever — are you going to be here long? If you're ever here, why you can come down to my house and I'll play you some of the — I'd like for you to come by my house.

MR: Well I'm going to be here all next week in Berkeley. Maybe I could come back.

EA: If you come by my house I could play some of my tapes for you. They're not professional tapes.

MR: No that's okay.

EA: It's a job you know, so you'll get an idea of what I did you know. Sure.

MR: Nelson Riddle.

EA: Well what I did, I was a contractor for the big Japanese shows that used to come here.

MR: Japanese shows?

EA: Yeah. They used to bring Japanese shows from Japan.

MR: Really.

EA: And they'd have big artists, singers, and I'd have to furnish the bands. And one time they brought a band here and Nelson Riddle was involved with something so he brought Jerome Richardson. Did you ever hear of Jerome?

MR: Yes.

EA: He played with me. He was another good buddy of mine. He played with me as a kid.

MR: Oh what a nice guy, yeah.

EA: He played with me when he was a kid. I forgot to mention his name.

MR: He played with me about four years ago.

EA: Oh you know Jerome Richardson?

MR: He played on a CD of mine.

EA: When Jerome Richardson was a kid we used to play in a lot of things together.

MR: I love it.

EA: Oh my goodness. Jerome played with me a lot of gigs. I love Jerome Richardson.

MR: He taught me a little phrase. We were doing this recording and we were rehearsing it a little bit and he goes, "Let's make it — let's make it." So we made it.

EA: Oh Jeez. Well I knew Jerome as a kid. See his father was raised up with Jack Johnson. His father used to tell me a story about him and Jack Johnson. Well he's from Berkeley, Jerome was. So I knew him as a kid. I said, "You're going to go back east?" He said, "Yeah I'm going to go back east. I will go back for about five years." Jerome, he went back east and boy, he made more records than anybody.

MR: Yeah he was on a lot of records.

EA: Another guy told me not to go in the music business was the guy, the head of Count Basie's band, what's his name? He played with me once.

MR: Marshall?

EA: Oh Marshall Royal played with me during the war. Marshall and Ernie both played with me during the war.

MA: Who are you thinking of then? Grover Mitchell?

EA: Grover Mitchell. I told Grover Mitchell — Grover Mitchell was working in the post office. I said, "Don't quit your day job." So one time years ago I saw him in Reno with the Count Basie Band and I'm laughing. Because he played with me. I was the boss. So many things like that you know. I don't know if you're getting anything out of an

interview with me, because I'm not like these other guys, no big shot or nothing. I knew a lot of them.

MR: Wow.

EA: Yeah Grover Mitchell, Jerome Richardson, Marshall Royal, Ernie Royal. Did you ever hear of Ernie Royal?

MR: Sure.

EA: Well during the war years my brother and Eddie Royal and Marshall Royal, they were in the Navy and they stayed here and they came to San Francisco for the gigs. So I was playing in a place called the Club Alabam. So they played with me at the Club Alabam. So all these great musicians played with me. And then Mingus was one of the greatest musicians you know. But he was a nut later on, Mingus.

MR: What was he like when you knew him?

EA: Well he was still sane when I met him.

MR: Well that's saying something.

EA: Yeah. But we got along pretty nice. But he sure changed after that, Jeez, he went crazy. But he was a genius they tell me. I guess. But he wasn't the type, a bad one to play in my band, I don't care how good he was.

MR: Oh okay. He was a little volatile, yeah.

EA: And way out you know.

MR: Yeah.

EA: But I played with him. Yeah. I remember one time Ben Webster had a little outfit, I told Ben Webster I played, at this little gig one time, so I told Ben Webster just come along with us. He didn't know we were — he said, "Have I got time to go back and get my horn?" I said, "No you haven't got time." "I didn't know you guys were this good?"

MR: Or he'd be playing with you. Wow.

EA: And he loved my tenor man, because my tenor man had a beautiful tone. Little stories like that.

MR: Right. What was your — when your band was in existence long enough that musical styles changed a lot, did you play some rock & roll?

EA: Not too much. I stayed with what I could really play good.

MR: Okay.

EA: Because I was never a good rock & roll drummer or musician, so I didn't play rock & roll. I played a couple of numbers.

MR: A couple of Beatle numbers?

EA: Oh I played a couple of them, you know, a couple, to satisfy people. But that wasn't my forte. I was more like Jimmie Lunceford, [inaudible] and other stuff you know and Benny Goodman stuff and Duke Ellington stuff, in that vein. Yeah.

MR: Did you have to play "I Left My Heart in San Francisco?"

EA: Oh my goodness I played that a lot. In fact I've got a picture of me and Tony Bennett at home I should have brought it.

MR: Really.

EA: Yeah.

MR: Well you've seen a lot.

EA: I've seen quite a bit for a guy going on 92.

MR: How do you spend your time now?

EA: Well right now, the last year or two I've kind of — my health kind of went down a little bit, gee I was very active. But in the last few months I feel little problems. But I try to keep my sense of humor anyway.

MR: Well you have that, that's for sure. That's great. Can you think of anything else that I should be asking you about?

EA: I've got some wonderful kids, oh my kids are good kids. I'm glad of them. Because that's why I'm glad I stayed home and didn't travel because — I benefited from having good kids, three boys and a girl and they all turned out to be good kids. If I traveled, I know some guys, they don't even know who their kids are. And I had a home life all my life. And that's where I wanted it. I wouldn't have played with my brother — although my brother was a big shot in that end of it but I wouldn't trade places. I'd rather have what I have. My daughter and my three boys.

MR: You got to rub elbows with all the great musicians.

EA: Yeah. They're the best.

MR: I know how you feel because I'm meeting people like you and I've met some of those other people and it's a great thing to be into.

EA: I'm like the bear, I'm nowhere.

MR: I think you're a little too modest. Yeah.

EA: A guy flew me down to — who's the guy who used to be a publisher at a paper, the Chronicle, oh he was a big shot, a publisher. And he heard my band one time. There's a college named for him down around L.A.

LA: Hearst?

EA: No. What's his name. He was the publisher of the Chronicle. You've heard of the Chronicle newspaper, haven't you?

MR: Oh sure.

EA: And he hired me. He said, "Eddie I want you to play for—" I says, "Where is it?" He says, "It's not too far from Los Angeles." I said — what's his name — and this town is named after his family.

LA: The only thing I can think of is Hearst.

EA: No. I've got a picture taken by his house. I said, "Boy they've got a lot of good bands in L.A." He said I want to hear your band. And so, "I want you to get a plane, I'll pay for the plane and I'll fly you down to this place." And he flew us down there and we played. And I'll tell you what I did. It was Armistice Day, I believe it was Armistice Day, and there was a great big open field and we had about five pieces. And I seen all these guys with veteran caps and things on and everything like that. And I said what am I going to do with a big crowd like that with my little outfit. So I played "Roses of Picardy" and "My Buddy." All these songs you know. They were veterans.

MR: And you had them, right?

EA: Next year I was back again.

MR: You figured it out immediately.

EA: See I could have flipped out and played bababoom, what's all that, and they wouldn't even have known I was there. I played something to touch them.

MR: Yeah, make that connection.

EA: That's the thing you have to do.

MR: Well I'm looking at this book here, "Jazz on the Barbary Coast." It's got a picture from 1934 at Purcell's.

EA: Yeah. That's the guy that said we couldn't play in North Beach in those days. And this guy said "they're going to play there." It wasn't my band. I played with another guy.

MR: Yeah. Elmer Clayborn.

EA: Yeah.

MR: Wes Peoples.

EA: Yeah. That's when Edwin Lowe and Lilyan Tashman, the first movie stars I've ever seen, came in the place.

MR: Wow. That's really interesting. I love it. That's history you know.

EA: I don't know if I added anything to your thing.

MR: Yeah, absolutely.

EA: Jerome Richardson. You know all those guys, huh?

MR: Yeah. I did a little recording a few years ago.

EA: How about the saxophone player, the white saxophone player that plays with Jerome, his best friend. He played with me too. I've got a picture at the Mod Hopkins. What's his name?

MR: Not Jerry Dodgion?

EA: Yeah. Jerry Dodgion? You know him?

MR: Yeah.

EA: Yeah he played with me. I played with some great names I'm telling you.

MR: Nice names. I'm a saxophone player myself.

EA: Oh yeah. Jerry Dodgion is a nice guy. See I had them all in this band. I played with some great guys.

MR: Well those guys make you play better.

EA: No doubt about it. No doubt about it.

MR: You know? It's like I'm not going to — sometimes you play better than you think you can.

EA: Oh sure you do.

MR: Because you just feel like I don't want to embarrass myself here.

EA: One of my best friends when I was a kid was named Waldo Carter, he played trumpet with — he used to play with Harry James and he played with a lot of the big bands. He called me every morning. He played with beautiful tone. If you ever come down to my house—

MR: I'll give it a try. I'll let you know where I am.

EA: Well it's just a little cassette. It's not a professional tape.

MR: That's all right. Well Tim can we get — well this has really been fascinating talking to you.

EA: Well I hope you got something out of it.

MR: I'm so glad that you were able to come.

EA: Because I didn't travel like these other guys.

MR: That's all right. You know it's not just the really, really big name people who have the stories, it's fellas like yourself, they don't get to tell it as much and I'm pleased that you were able to.

EA: Human stories.

MR: That's right. So thank you very much.